

Tamil Nadu,” he said. But as he spoke about the Pirates match, a flicker of disappointment crossed his face. It’s not often you meet a fan dejected after a win of that scale.

“We’ve had underwhelming performances. It’s great to see them perform like this, but I think it’s too little, too late now,” he said. “When they got Arjun and Pawan Sehrawat in the auction, I thought we could go all the way. But it wasn’t meant to be, I guess.”

The Thalaivas, despite being in the PKL since Season Five, have qualified for the playoffs just once, in 2022. Yet even through his frustration, Kavi’s voice lifted when the talk turned to local talent. He singled out Arul Babu of the Thalaivas for his sharp play and even mentioned Patna’s Sudhakar, arguing that the raider had far more to offer than his current role suggested. He was convinced Tamil Nadu’s deep talent pool would eventually make its mark in the league.

As the cab pulled away from the stadium, the Diary contemplated the strange mathematics of fandom, where 57 points could still feel like zero.

Nigamanth P.

Kabaddi’s cathedral finds its congregation

The SDAT Multipurpose Stadium roared back to life during the thrilling final two days of the Pro Kabaddi League (PKL) Season 12 Chennai leg, silencing any murmurs about low turnouts earlier in the leg. The city’s deep-rooted passion for sport, especially for kabaddi, came alive in a vibrant spectacle.

It was a true testament to Chennai’s reputation: fans didn’t just turn up, they poured through the gates. The final day was a complete packed house, the energy so palpable that hopeful fans queued outside, praying for a last-minute ticket to the action.

The atmosphere did more than impress the locals; it lifted the players too. As U Mumba skipper and India international Sunil Kumar put it, “The Chennai crowd has always been incredibly supportive of



kabaddi. It doesn’t matter if the Tamil Thalaivas are playing or not, they always cheer us on. I think this is the noisiest crowd in the country, and that energy gives us extra motivation to perform well on the mat.”

The roaring crowd did more than cheer. It reignited the spark in the PKL’s ‘Showman’, Mohammadreza Shadloui. This season, the towering Iranian had looked a shadow of his brilliant self. But in the leg’s final match, the Gujarat Giants defender delivered a defiant display that reminded everyone why he commands the league’s highest price tag. The deafening stands left no doubt that in this city, kabaddi is a celebration.

Saikat Chakraborty

Beating the clock, barely

The 12th season of the Pro Kabaddi League has seen several matches decided by a player’s ability — or inability — to dive back into their half in time. On one of the final Chennai leg days, the Diary got a small taste of that very pressure, albeit through slightly unfortunate circumstances.

By midweek, the matchday arrival routine ran on autopilot. The Diary would enter through the side gate at the SDAT Indoor Stadium, flash its

Home pulse: The SDAT crowd turned the Chennai leg into a festival, where devotion met decibels and the mat became a shared celebration. PKL MEDIA

accreditation to the guard, and walk down the narrow path lined with hoardings of PKL’s biggest names. Another quick ID check at the final barrier, and entry was granted.

This well-oiled process came undone on the last day of coverage. Stopped at the final checkpoint, the Diary was asked for the accreditation that should have been hanging around its neck. A quick glance downward revealed only an empty lanyard. With the first raid minutes away, entry was suddenly impossible.

A frantic search followed as the Diary retraced its steps along the path, scanning every patch of ground in growing panic. Just when the clock threatened to beat it, an alert security guard came to the rescue, holding up the missing ID that had slipped unnoticed onto the floor. Thanks to the guard’s timely intervention, the Diary made it inside just in time — grateful for the save, and with a new respect for those who beat the clock to reach back across the line.

Aditya Padinjat